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LABOUR PARTY AND ISRAEL

Broken Pledges During Mandatory Era

To the Editor of THE JEWISH CHRONICLE

SIR,—Perhaps Mr. Landman is, as Mr. Schaffer suggests (in your last week's issue), capable of futile polemics, and perhaps he is a source of amusement. And perhaps he is not. But would it not be wiser, and more decent, for critics of his writings to concentrate on the pros and cons of his arguments, and refrain from public sneers and jeers on and of a man who, after all, has given a lifetime of service and time to the Jewish people and the Zionist movement? Surely Mr. Landman deserves better than this. And it certainly is a matter of speculation how much this sort of public (and private) denigration, together with pettiness and spite, has turned people away from Zionist politics.

As regards the nature of Mr. Landman's expressed views on the Labour Party and Israel, it certainly is not un-understandable that thinking people who remember the disgraceful manner in which Labour broke every one of its pledges on Palestine during the years leading up to the termination of the Mandate should feel bitter and cynical upon relying on any expressed view and/or pledge that the Labour Party might make. And what I can only call the latest puerile statement of Earl Attlee on Israel is enough to drive people if not to drink—then at least to print! For my part, I thought that Mr. Landman was far too generous in his estimation of Earl Attlee's motives. (It is interesting to remember when giving appreciation to Earl Attlee's "mistake" remark that in 1943 he proposed a motion at a Labour Party conference that the Palestine Arabs should be encouraged to move out as the Jews moved in, and that Transjordan should be made part of a future Jewish State.)

Mr. Schaffer is certainly right in stressing the necessity of keeping all sections of British public opinion and political thought informed on developments in Israel, and it certainly is to the best advantage of Israel that an atmosphere of sympathy should be built up wherever possible. But let us as well remember that all governments when put to the test will act according to their practical needs and not according to sentimental pronouncements. And Mr. Landman by reminding us of past Labour defections helps to bring home to us this hard lesson.

M. R. GERSHLICK.

22 Cranley Road,
Westcliff-on-Sea.

Harsh Comments

SIR,—I believe that Mr. Schaffer (who wrote last week) has been unduly harsh on his colleague, Mr. Landman, for his comments on the anti-Israeli outbursts of Lord Attlee and Mr. Gaitskell. Periodically, leading members of the Labour and Conservative Parties criticise Israel. It is, therefore, a natural reaction for members of the Jewish community to voice their protests.

The British press cherishes a jealously guarded freedom—a freedom which is shared by correspondents who besiege editors with strong opinions and literary masterpieces.

There can be no doubt that Mr. Schaffer, in his capacity of Public Relations Officer for the Zionist Federation, capably performs an important and difficult task. But surely he goes beyond his jurisdiction when he expresses a desire to censor the letters of his executive members.

BEN OSEN.

17 Hill House,
Springfield, E.5.

Jewish M.P.s

SIR,—May I dot an "i" and cross a "t" in Mr. Landman's letter in your issue of August 22.

It would be catastrophic to count on the British Labour Party, if and when it attains power, implementing the pious expressions of good will towards Israel which is uttered by many of its members while in opposition. The late Mr. Bevin was a member of that Party when it was in power and his name is linked with the collective responsibility of it as a whole; we all, alas! know what that policy was.

Back-benchers in both parties carry little weight in the making of policy and it is sad to see so much of the all too few £s and $s which should be spent in developing Israel devoted to sponsoring the journeys of M.P.s to and from that country.

It is as futile to pin our faith on their official support as it is to pin it on the effective support of the Jewish M.P.s. These were elected to support their constituents, not their fellow Jews, and why should they risk their whip? Indeed, if they do give effective support to Israel in the House of Commons let us be thankful but do not let us count on it.

CYRIL HENRIQUES.

4 Campden Hill Square, W.8.

SIR,—If the last paragraph of Mr. Samuel Landman's letter (in your issue of August 22) be true—and who may challenge it?—the observation of Earl Attlee need not worry us overmuch.

True the Earl is no longer Leader of the Labour Party, but he is of that party which subscribes so wholeheartedly to the principle—"Policy is the best honesty." Nor ought we be dismayed at the foolish remark of the Leader of the Opposition which added nothing to his stature as a statesman. The Labour Party once shone with idealists and there may be some left—enough indeed to redeem the city.

HENRY SNOWMAN.

21/22 Dunraven Street, W.1.

SIR,—Mr. Goldberg's correction in his letter of last week is incomplete. Mr. Greenwood's Brains Trust speech, made in reply to a question from me, also included the somewhat surprising statement that the reason the DAILY HERALD and the NEW STATESMAN made no reference to the Tenth Anniversary was only that they did not consider it of interest from the journalistic point of view.

Even more surprising, however, is the hectoring attempt of Mr. Schaffer to educate Mr. Landman. I myself have reason to know that there are many Gentile Englishmen of all parties who are sufficiently aware of this country's true interests in the Middle East to support Israel and I see no point in dwelling on the past. But it is surely an insult to the intelligence and the patriotism of these real friends of Israel to suggest that they might change their attitude—which I think is the correct interpretation of Mr. Schaffer's "incalculable harm"—merely because an individual Jew lets himself go on the basis of once bitten twice shy. In any case, Mr. Schaffer really ought to remember that politicians when in a position to act invariably do so on first thoughts.

LAWRENCE WOLFE.

76 Onslow Gardens,
London, S.W.7.

MISS MILLIE GARCIA, the singer, entertained the Finchley Friendship Club at a recent meeting at the home of Mrs. B. Lebolt (Decoy Avenue, N.W.11).

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APPEAL FOR CLOTHING

Refugees at the Shelter

To the Editor of THE JEWISH CHRONICLE

SIR,—May we appeal once again through your columns on behalf of our protégés who are in need of clothing.

The magnificent response to our appeal early in 1957 was, of course, almost exhausted by distribution among the Hungarian and Egyptian refugees who were being cared for at the Shelter. The present residents of the Shelter come mainly from India, where economic conditions are forcing a minor, but fairly constant, migration. Most of these people come rather scantily clad, and quite unprepared for the comparative rigours of an English autumn and winter.

The urgent need is for new clothing, or worn clothing in very good condition, for men, women, and children; but we do most respectfully ask that badly worn articles are not sent as these cause embarrassment, both because of lack of space and shortage of staff.

Gifts, which will be individually acknowledged, should be sent to the Secretary at the Shelter, 63 Mansell Street, London, E.1.

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About Books

THE BIBLE IN ENGLISH

A New Imprint

The Holy Scriptures: According to the Masoretic Text: A New Translation: With the aid of previous versions and with constant consultation of Jewish authorities. **Philadelphia:** *Jewish Publication Society of America. London: Cambridge University Press.* 15s. 6d.

Reviewed by **HUGH HARRIS**

This English version of the Hebrew Bible has rightly become a modern classic and is now everywhere recognised by English-speaking Jews as the standard version in the vernacular. In their preface to the original edition of 1917, the translators expressed their objective as follows:

"It aims to combine the spirit of Jewish tradition with the results of Biblical scholarship, ancient, medieval, and modern. It gives to the Jewish world a translation of the Scriptures done by men imbued with the Jewish consciousness, while the non-Jewish world, it is hoped, will welcome a translation that presents many passages from the Jewish traditional point of view."

This splendid objective was completely achieved; and during the past forty years this renowned work has constantly been reprinted to a total of hundreds of thousands of copies.

British Jewry is now greatly indebted to the enterprise of the Cambridge University Press, which has just produced a reprinting of this volume that will make it far more readily obtainable in this country and at a much more reasonable price than hitherto. This is a real service not only to the Jewish community but to Bible-lovers of all faiths; and it is in fine keeping with the traditions of the Cambridge University Press, which is famed for its productions in the field of Biblical literature.

On the title-page, however, appears an erroneous ascription: "The Jewish Publications Society of America." Moreover, on the verso appear the words: "Second Impression, August, 1917" (apparently through the reprinting by photolithography using that very early impression). This is unfortunate, as some forty impressions have since appeared.

As well as the ordinary edition, the Jewish Publication Society produced in 1955 a new edition, which differed not only in format and type but also contained a number of internal changes, such as the respelling of some archaic words and the correction of a number of misprints, although no other changes were made in the text of the translation.

Seventieth Anniversary

However, Biblical scholarship does not stand still. In 1953 it was announced that the leading rabbinical bodies in the United States—the Central Conference of American Rabbis (Reform), the Rabbinical Assembly (Conservative), and the Rabbinical Council (Orthodox)—were setting up a committee to undertake, in conjunction with the Jewish Publication Society of America, a new English translation of the Bible. It was then estimated that this work might take a decade to complete.

These observations, of course, in no way diminish the gratitude that is due to the Cambridge University Press for the present production. It appears, appropriately enough, in the year that marks the seventieth anniversary of the Jewish Publication Society. And it also affords another reminder that the English Bible constitutes one of the strongest links in the chain which binds together the great English-speaking countries.

ASPECTS OF ITALIAN JEWRY

Over Twenty Centuries

Scritti in Memoria di Sally Mayer (1875-1953). Jerusalem: published for the Sally Mayer **Foundation, Institute** of Jewish Studies, **Milan.**

Reviewed by **LEON ROTH**

The late Sally Mayer was an industrialist of great wealth who came to Italy from Germany as a boy and became an Italian citizen after the First World War. Between the wars he built up a fortune, and after the end of the second devoted his remarkable energy and abilities to the rehabilitation of Italian Jewry. He seems to have re-created Jewish life in his home city, Milan. He reorganised it from top to bottom, refounding its school and reconstituting its charitable institutions; but not (we are assured) from "above"! The service he gave was personal, and nothing was too small for his loving care. He would join the schoolchildren in their excursions as readily as he would guide his numerous committees and conduct a campaign for some public Jewish cause. He worked for the community day and night, and enjoyed it. When he was killed in a motor accident in 1953 he was universally mourned as friend and father as well as benefactor.

Transference to Israel

The volume issued in his memory contains a collection of studies on various aspects of Italian Jewry, two-thirds of which are in Italian and one-third in Hebrew, the Hebrew portion including contributions from the President of the State of Israel, the Ashkenazi Chief Rabbi, and a former Prime Minister of the State. The essays cover points of regional, diplomatic, religious, and social history, the history of art and music (chazanut), demography, literature, and education; while the most recent history is represented on the one hand by an article on modern Italian Jewish painters, on the other by a memoir of Enzo Sereni and a description of the part taken by Italian Jewry in helping the refugees of the immediate post-war period. For the general student of the Jewish scene perhaps the most significant [illegible] by the account of the transference to communities of the Italian rite in Israel of the appurtenances of disused synagogues in Italy. This is illustrated by photographs which form a striking collection [illegible] but which may well arouse melancholy reflections on the breaking-up involved in the present centrifugal tendency of world Jewry.

Since the volume [illegible] Italian summaries of the [illegible] and Hebrew summaries of the Italian, everybody (almost) [illegible] continuous Jewish life of over twenty centuries which it brings so vividly to the mind is an important subject for our instruction and meditation.

With its superb print, paper, binding, and, above all, illustrations, the volume reflects a remarkable combination of Italian taste and Jerusalem technical skill.

VANISHED CITIES

Vanished Cities. By HERMANN and GEORG SCHREIBER. Translated by RICHARD and CLARA WINSTON. *Weidenfeld and Nicolson.* 25s.

Reviewed by **R. D. BARNETT**

This book is another addition to the ever-growing line on my bookshelf of recent popular works on archæology. The authors have woven a series of descriptions of ancient civilisations in different parts of the world round the not inappropriate theme of their destruction by various agencies, such as war or the forces of nature, volcano, and hungry sea.

This romantic approach allows them to introduce much that is not archæology but just gossip, ancient and modern. Apart from much else that they cull from ancient authors, what but gossip is the tale of Atlantis, even if it began life in a dialogue of Plato? These platonic, so-called myths are only moral tales dressed up for a purpose. So, too, the legend of the lost cities of Sodom and Gomorrah, though sanctified by Holy Writ, has not yet achieved the status of archæological confirmation. The artificiality of the authors' chain of links permits them, too, to hurry us breathlessly hither and thither with a jerk from Sodom to Ys in Brittany, from Angkor in Cambodia to the Caroline Islands and Polynesia, in fact from China to Peru, if it suits the theme of their narrative, leaving us not a little bewildered by these odd meanderings.

But the book has merit. The account of ancient Babylon is confused; the god of Babylon was not Baal but Bel (Marduk); and some of the line-drawings are wrongly captioned. Yet the authors have obviously read and studied widely and wisely; and though they mix fact and fiction too freely, they report and summarise well, and have included much curious and interesting information (which I, for one, did not know) about such things as the lost people of the Canaries and Zimbabwe and other strange wonders of the past.

Moral, Aesthetic, and Religious Insight, by Theodore Meyer Greene (Mark Paterson, London, for Rutgers University Press, New Brunswick, 22s.), is a notable new contribution to the distinguished Brown and Haley Lectures series.

WOMEN PIONEERS

Daughters from Afar: Profiles of Israeli Women. By GERALDINE STERN. *Abelard-Schuman.* 16s.

Reviewed by **MIRIAM WARBURG**

It is always difficult to write about living people—and especially about such "outsize" personalities as the ones with whom this book deals. Most writers are too easily inclined to idealise those about whom they write and thus to de-humanise them and to ignore those features and incidents which make them real living people. In addition there is, naturally, always the consideration that one must not write anything which may embarrass or offend the person whom one admires so much. Geraldine Stern has succumbed to these pitfalls, too. Not in all her stories (I almost wrote "articles"—because this book is the work of a true journalist), but in some of them she succeeds in bringing her heroines to life—in others they remain mere statues.

Who are these women about whom she writes? They are the women pioneers of Israel, who have helped to build Israel under tremendous sacrifices with a stamina, courage, and almost incredible endurance which must arouse deepest admiration. Some of them—like Golda Meir and the actress Rovina—are well known outside Israel, others have made their name only inside the country. But just those with the world-wide fame—and this refers especially to Golda Meir—are Geraldine Stern's least human creations. One would have liked to read more incidents like the rather macabre joke which Geraldine Stern relates about her: When Golda arrived in New York after the declaration of the State, her sister Clara hurried to meet her at the Waldorf Astoria Hotel. She was kept waiting for some time, and when she was asked to come up, she was startled to find a woman wearing flowing Arab dress, her face heavily veiled. When a voice said: "Hello! Clara," she recognised her sister, who had put on the same disguise she had chosen for her meeting with Abdullah. Stories like that may have revealed much more about the "real Golda" than the enumeration of the many achievements of hers, most of which we know anyhow.

Touching Stories

But how can Geraldine Stern penetrate to the "real thing" if all she does is to invite her heroine for a cup of tea in a café, or to go to see her in her flat or place of work and talk a few hours with her? She "interviews" her women but she does not live their lives with them. That, in spite of this, she succeeds in writing some fascinating, touching, and often harrowing, stories, is obviously due to her outstanding ability to induce people whom she has just met to tell her about their lives and their problems. She has selected these people most skilfully from all walks of life and from immigrants from all over the world. There is never a repetition: each chapter tells a new and interesting story.

BIBLE AND TALMUD

Vision Press are the U.K. distributors for several books published in New York by Twayne Publishers and Bookman Associates: **A Treasury of Bible Stories,** by Hyman E. Goldin (40s.): **Treasury of Holiday Thoughts,** by **Israel Tabak** (32s.): **Meet the Prophets,** by David Goldby (22s.): **The Talmud,** by Isaac Unterman (36s.): **The Growth of the Pentateuch,** by Immanuel Lewy (36s.).

PAPERBACKS

Three valuable books, finely reprinted in paper-cover editions and published in America by Meridian Books and the Jewish Publication Society, are now available for readers in this country through the Mayflower Publishing Co.: **For the Sake of Heaven,** by Martin Buber (12s.): **Students, Scholars, and Saints,** by Louis Ginzberg (12s.): **A History of Medieval Jewish Philosophy,** by Isaac Husik (16s.).

BOOK BRIEFS

העמקת התודעה היהודית הישראלית published by the Israeli Ministry of Education and Culture, is a report of a conference of Israeli educationists, held last December in Tel Aviv, on ways and means of deepening the Jewish consciousness of Israeli schoolchildren.

אברהם העברי (Essays in honour of Abraham Recanati's 70th birthday), Jubilee Committee, 123 Rehov Nachalat Binyamin, Tel Aviv), comprises biographical essays and tributes to a Zionist leader, who, before he settled in Eretz Yisrael, was active in Salonika, where for some years he was the JEWISH CHRONICLE correspondent.

[illegible], by Yehuda Radai (Rubin Mass, Jerusalem), is the first part of a text-book of Modern Hebrew for somewhat advanced adult students. It is based on interesting and partly novel methods of teaching Hebrew in Israel.

The U.K. distributors of [illegible] by Moshe Gordon, reviewed in our issue of August 15, should have been given as R. Golub & Co., 5 Osborn Street, E.1.

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